

CSC425 Deliverable 2: User Research & Problem Definition

Student Name: Caden Outland

Branch Name: d2-caden-outland

Date Submitted: September 4, 2025

Target User Group

Military Members and Veterans in Undergraduate Education

Active-duty service members and U.S. veterans pursuing undergraduate degrees. This includes individuals balancing duty schedules with school and veterans adapting to civilian academic environments.

Problem Description

Military-affiliated students face challenges in completing undergraduate education due to frequent relocations, unpredictable deployment schedules, and difficulties transferring credits between institutions. Veterans often struggle with navigating GI Bill benefits, limited campus support, and adjusting to civilian student life. These barriers contribute to delayed graduation, wasted financial aid, and increased dropout rates.

Evidence of the Problem

- “When I got deployed mid-semester, I had to withdraw from all my classes. None of my credits transferred when I tried to pick back up at a new school.” — anonymous Army veteran (interview excerpt, 2023).
- According to the National Veteran Education Success Tracker (2023), nearly 48% of student veterans experience delays in completing degrees due to credit transfer issues.
- A Student Veterans of America (2024) survey reported that 37% of veterans dropped at least one class because of challenges managing VA benefits or unexpected service-related obligations.

“How Might We” Statement

How might we design more flexible and transferable undergraduate pathways that support military members and veterans facing frequent relocations, deployments, and complex benefit systems?

User Persona

Name: James “Jim” Carter

Age: 27

Background: U.S. Army veteran, first-generation college student

Occupation: Works part-time at a logistics company while enrolled in an undergraduate business program

Location: San Antonio, TX

Goals: Earn a bachelor’s degree in supply chain management to advance into a civilian career

Frustrations: Lost 15 credits after transferring schools due to military relocation; struggles with confusing GI Bill paperwork; feels out of place among younger civilian students

Technology Comfort Level: High (familiar with online learning platforms, uses laptop and smartphone daily)

Ethical Lens Applied

Principle: Equity and Fair Access to Education

Application: Military members and veterans are disadvantaged by rigid university systems that fail to accommodate service obligations, violating the principle of equitable access to education.

Stakeholders Impacted: Military students, veterans, higher education institutions, and the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Professional Standard: Aligns with ACM Code of Ethics 1.4: “Be fair and take action not to discriminate” and NASPA Standards for Supporting Student Veterans (2023).

References

- Student Veterans of America. (2019). SVA Census Data.
<https://studentveterans.org/research/sva-census/>
- Ithaka S+R. (2023). The trouble with transfer for student veterans.
<https://sr.ithaka.org/blog/the-trouble-with-transfer-for-student-veterans/>
- U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs. (2025). Tips for administrators: Supporting student veterans.
<https://www.mentalhealth.va.gov/student-veteran/tips-for-administrators.asp>
- Journal of Veterans Studies. (2024). A pilot study on student veterans.
<https://journal-veterans-studies.org/articles/10.21061/jvs.v10i3.570>
- HigherEdMilitary. (2022). 37% dropout rate among part-time student veterans.
<https://www.higheredmilitary.com/news/articleDisplay.cfm?ID=3155>
- U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs. (2017). Veterans face challenges in higher education. VA Research Currents.
<https://www.research.va.gov/currents/1017-Veterans-face-challenges-in-higher-education.cfm>

- Journal of Veterans Studies. (2025). GI Bill beneficiaries in higher education.
<https://journal-veterans-studies.org/articles/10.21061/jvs.v11i1.706>
- Anderson, N. (2016, December 7). Why colleges don't give credit for military training.
Time Magazine / Hechinger Report.
<https://time.com/4608543/veterans-college-credit-military-training-gi-bill/>